

DCS MISSION STARTER

USER GUIDE

Pick a map, an era, and an aircraft — fly a living world in minutes.
Airfields dressed. SAMs up. The strike group at sea. No waypoints, ever.

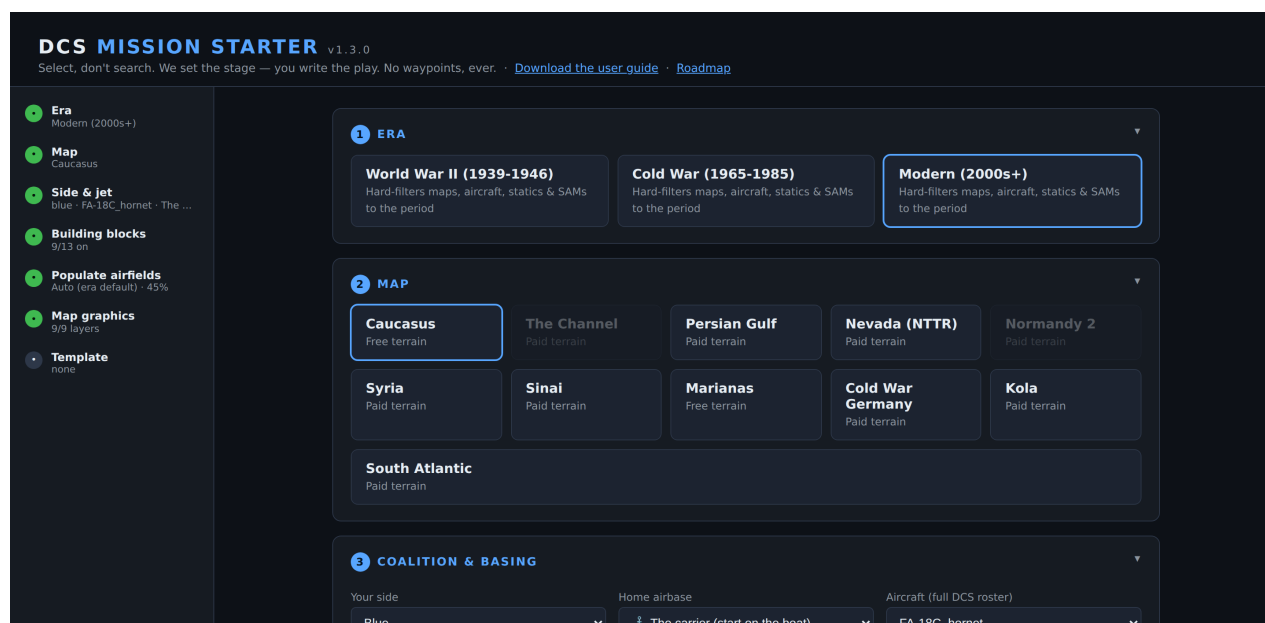
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Welcome aboard

Select, don't search. The DCS Mission Starter builds a living world for you: airfields dressed with period-correct aircraft and equipment, working SAM sites, support flights on station, and a carrier strike group with a properly spotted deck. You download a ready **.miz** file and build *your* mission on top in the DCS Mission Editor.

We set the stage — you write the play. The Starter never places your waypoints. Flight planning is always yours.



The Mission Starter wizard.

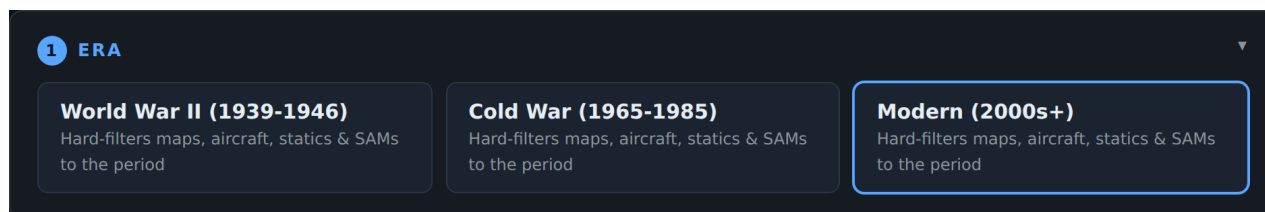
Finding your way

The **progress rail** on the left tracks every step with its current value and goes green as you make choices — click any step to jump there. Section headers fold a finished section out of the way. **Generate and the share link are always one click away** in the rail. Your work saves itself: close the browser mid-build and everything is exactly where you left it when you come back ("Reset wizard" starts fresh).

Step by step

Step 1 — Pick an era

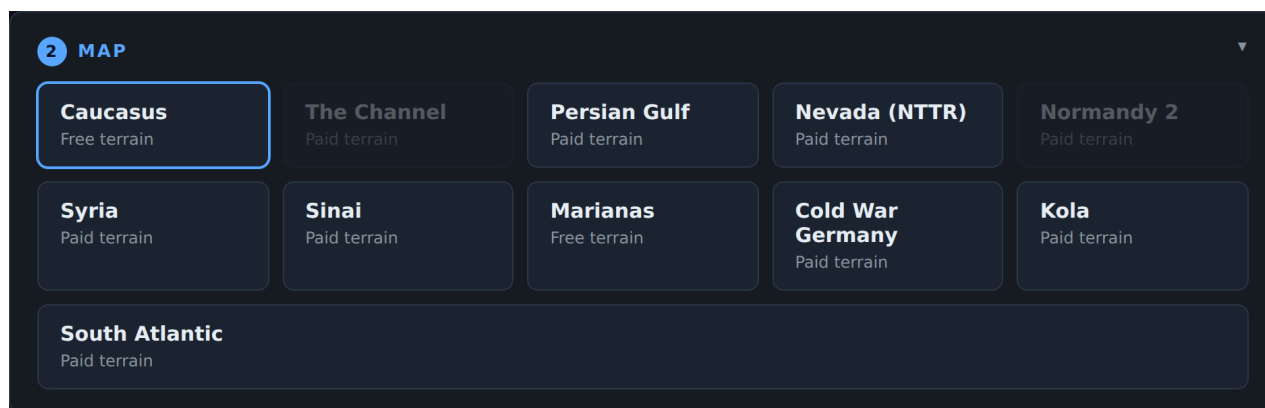
Start with **when**. The era is the master filter: it decides which maps, aircraft, statics, SAMs, and support assets can appear. A WWII starter will not offer a Hornet, and a modern starter will not offer a Spitfire.



Step 1: era selection — the period drives everything downstream.

Step 2 — Pick a map

Choose your theater. Maps without content for the chosen era are greyed out — pick WWII and the Channel, Normandy, and the 1944 Marianas light up. The Marianas carries all three eras — 1944 campaign, Arc Light era, and modern. Cold War Germany puts you on the Inner German Border (Fulda Gap west, GDR fields east); Kola covers NATO's Northern Flank, with the carrier group stationed in the Norwegian Sea off Andoya; Sinai in the Cold War era is October 1973 — Israel holds the Sinai fields taken in '67 while Egypt's canal-front bases sit under the SAM belt, and the 6th Fleet steams north of Port Said. Every map's preset carries its major airfields on both sides — on the NTTR that includes Groom Lake and the Tonopah Test Range as blue, selectable home plates (they are USAF fields; even the captured MiGs there flew as USAF units).



Step 2: map selection — eleven theaters, filtered by the era you chose.

Step 3 — Coalition, basing & aircraft

Pick your side, home airfield, and aircraft from the full DCS flyable roster (period-filtered). Set single-player or multiplayer slots, start type, time, weather, and world density.

3 COALITION & BASING

Your side

Blue

Home airbase

 The carrier (start on the boat)

Aircraft (full DCS roster)

FA-18C_hornet

Slots (1 = single player)

1

Start

cold

Time

day

Weather

clear

Density

normal

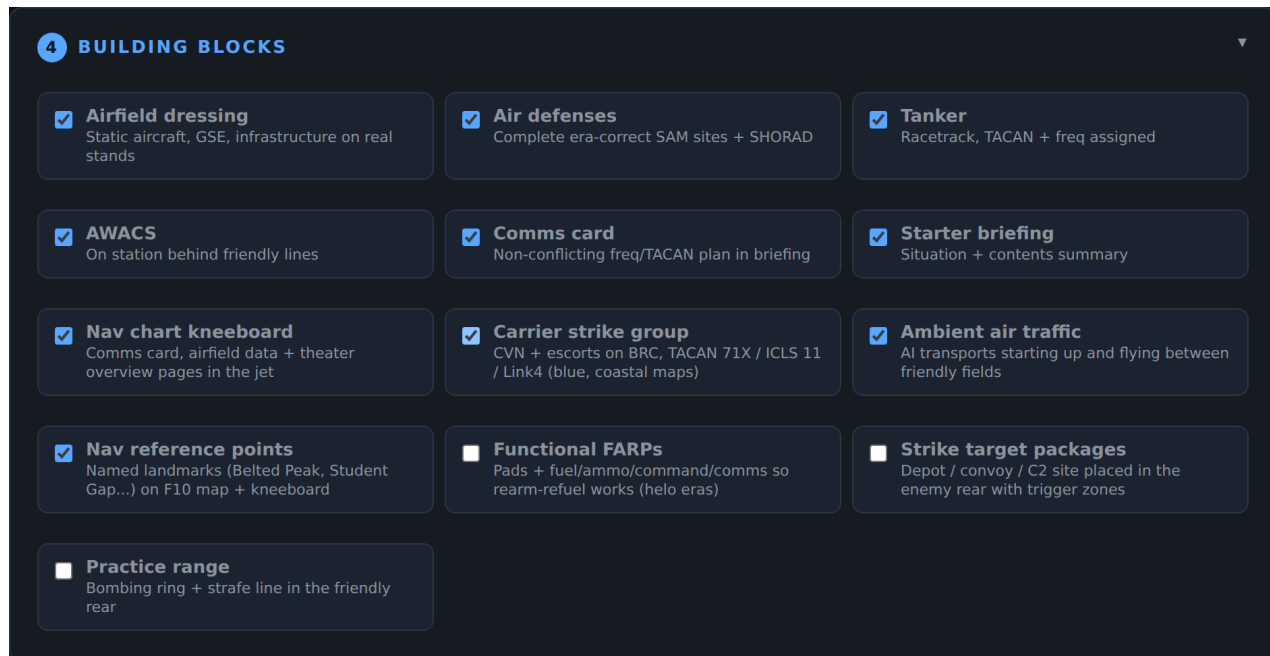
Seed

1

Step 3: side, home plate, aircraft, and mission conditions.

Step 4 — Choose building blocks

Everything is optional and defaults are sensible. Each block is described in the reference table later in this guide.



Step 4: the building-block toggles.

Step 4a — Populate airfields

Decide exactly how your fields are dressed. The **fill slider** sets exactly what share of each field's fillable stands gets a parked aircraft — 75% means 75%. The **placement mode** is a real tradeoff: *Static* (default) loads instantly, is an inert static object — no AI pilot, so it uses far less memory and CPU, loads instantly, and never appears as a map contact. Its facing is exact on the surveyed maps (all but Falklands and The Channel) and a best-effort guess elsewhere. *AI aircraft* are live uncontrolled units — they align exactly to the painted line on any map, but they cost memory and frames and can hurt FPS on lower-end PCs, so Static is recommended. *AI-parked* aligns each aircraft exactly to the painted parking line (DCS places it), but the aircraft are heavier, show as map contacts, and stream in over the first seconds. The three toggles switch parked aircraft, ground equipment, and the infrastructure cluster independently. The **ramp theme** decides WHO parks there, with weighted realistic mixes and strict era gating. "Auto" picks the right ramp for the map — Nellis dresses as a US Air Force base, not a Navy ramp. Select **Red Flag exercise** and the NTTR fills out like exercise season: B-1 and B-52 heavies on the big ramp squares, aggressor Vipers, and Navy and allied visitors — a Hornet, a Mirage, a Tornado among the Eagles. Enemy fields always dress with their own era-correct theme, and runways and taxi routes always stay clear.



Step 4a: fill percentage, object types, and the ramp theme — Red Flag selected.

The Ramp Composer — pick exact aircraft

When a theme isn't specific enough, open the **Ramp Composer** inside Populate airfields and build the ramp by hand. Aircraft are grouped by role — Fighters & Attack, Bombers & Heavies, Tankers, AWACS & ISR, Transport, Helicopters — and each type has a count. Want six Vipers, four Apaches, a pair of B-1s, a tanker and an AWACS on the ground? Set the numbers. Counts are **per airfield** and era-filtered (a WWII composer offers warbirds, never a B-1), and placement is stand-aware: helicopters go on pads, heavies on the large ramp squares, everything else on fighter stands, with anything beyond a field's capacity skipped. Any counts here override the ramp theme and fill for your side's fields; leave them all at zero to use the theme. The exact composition rides the share link, so a squadron-mate who clicks it gets the same ramp.

Step 4c — Map graphics (F10)

The map briefs the mission. Each layer draws real mission geometry on the F10 map: the tanker's racetrack with its freq/TACAN label, the AWACS orbit, carrier CAP and Hawkeye stations, the strike group's ops box with a BRC arrow, amber rings over target packages and the range, FARP service rings, bullseye, and — the intel picture — known enemy SAM engagement rings at doctrinal radii. Friendly orbits and threat rings render on YOUR coalition's layer only, so in multiplayer the enemy never sees your picture (or gets their own SAMs highlighted). Uncheck any layer for a cleaner map. Zones inform — they never route you.

4C MAP GRAPHICS (F10)

☒ **Tanker track**
Racetrack + TEXACO freq/TACAN/altitude label

☒ **AWACS orbit**
OVERLORD station behind friendly lines

☒ **Carrier CAP station**
Air-wing 2-ship racetrack on the threat axis

☒ **Hawkeye AEW orbit**
E-2 station covering the strike group

☒ **Carrier ops box**
CSG operating area + BRC arrow

☒ **Target & range rings**
Amber ring + name over each strike package / practice range

☒ **FARP rings**
Service radius + name at each FARP

☒ **Bullseye**
Shared reference marker (both sides)

☒ **Threat rings (intel)**
Known enemy SAM engagement rings — YOUR side's map only

hornet from Nellis · seed 1

COPY SHARE LINK

GENERATE

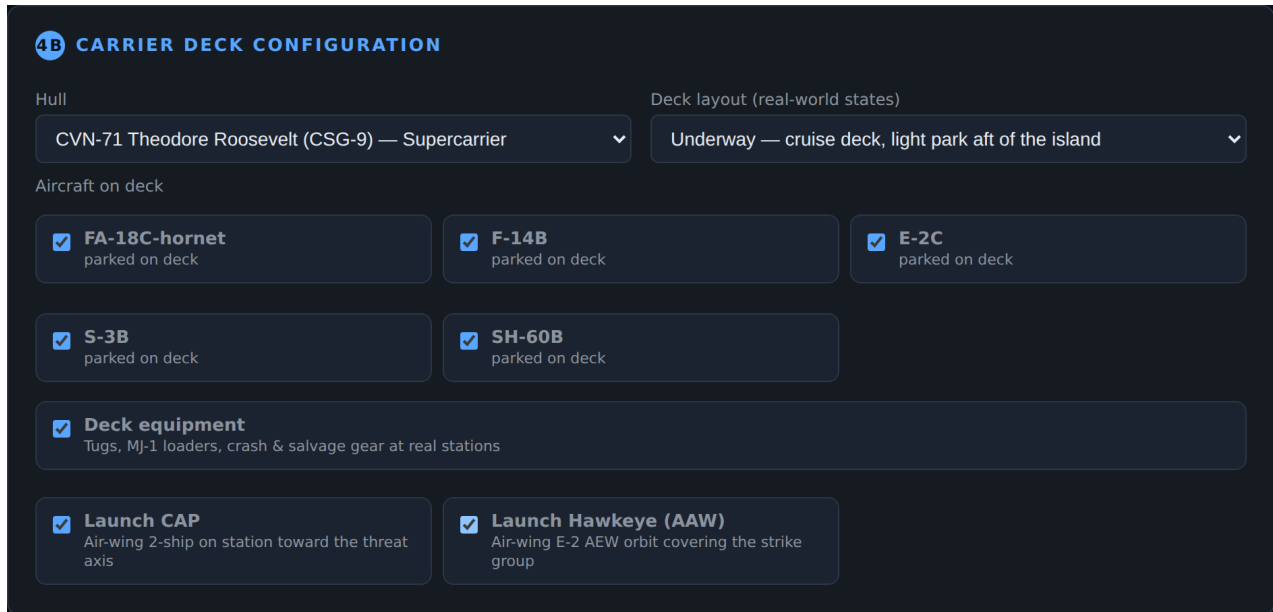
Step 4c: the map-graphics layer picker.

Step 4d — Threat level

The **Threat Dial** sets how hard the mission pushes back. **Intensity** (Minimal → Maximum) controls how many extra area SAM sites and airborne enemy CAP flights spawn on top of the SAM defending each enemy airfield — the count is rolled off the mission seed, so two re-rolls at the same setting give a different picture. **System level** sets the calibre: *Era standard* uses the period's historical mix; *Light* leans on legacy kit (SA-2/SA-3, MiG-21/23) for a trainer-friendly fight; *Heavy* brings the modern long-range threats (SA-10/SA-11, Su-27/MiG-31); *Mixed* rolls the pool per site. Everything is era-gated — a WWII field never fields an SA-10, and a Cold War push tops out at the MiG-23. The enemy CAP orbits on the threat axis and engages you inbound; the area SAMs form a belt you have to plan around. Turn the base **Air defenses** block off and the dial stands down with it.

Step 4b — Configure the carrier (optional)

With the carrier block enabled, pick a hull, a real-world deck state, the aircraft spotted on deck, and optionally launch the air wing's CAP and Hawkeye.



4B CARRIER DECK CONFIGURATION

Hull: CVN-71 Theodore Roosevelt (CSG-9) — Supercarrier

Deck layout (real-world states): Underway — cruise deck, light park aft of the island

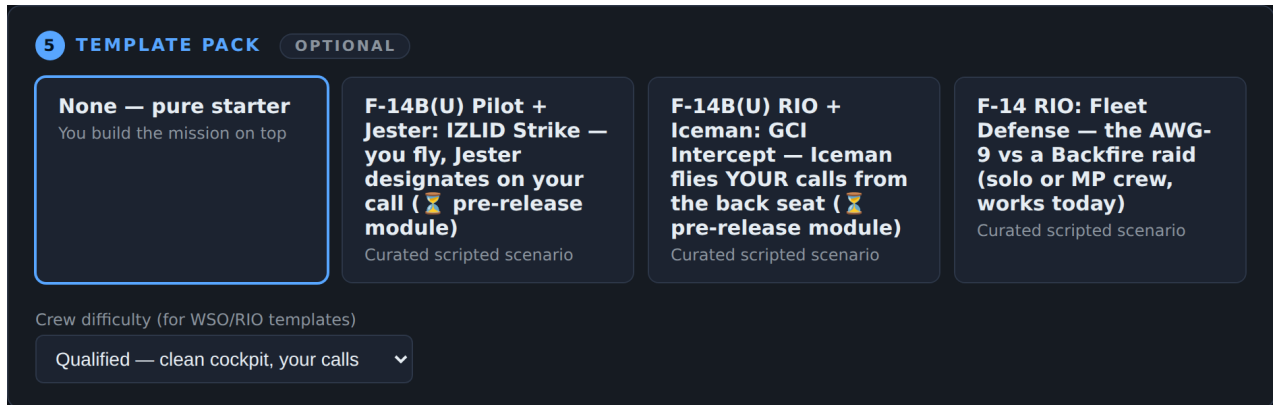
Aircraft on deck:

- ☒ FA-18C-hornet parked on deck
- ☒ F-14B parked on deck
- ☒ E-2C parked on deck
- ☒ S-3B parked on deck
- ☒ SH-60B parked on deck
- ☒ Deck equipment: Tugs, MJ-1 loaders, crash & salvage gear at real stations
- ☒ Launch CAP: Air-wing 2-ship on station toward the threat axis
- ☒ Launch Hawkeye (AAW): Air-wing E-2 AEW orbit covering the strike group

Step 4b: the Roosevelt with a recovery deck, full airwing, CAP and AAW Hawkeye.

Step 5 — Template pack (optional), then Generate

Pick a curated scenario or keep the pure starter, then hit **GENERATE .MIZ**. Drop the file in *Saved Games/DCS/Missions/* and fly, or open it in the Mission Editor and keep building. **Copy share link** gives you a URL that regenerates this exact starter for anyone who clicks it — paste it in your squadron Discord.



5 TEMPLATE PACK OPTIONAL

None — pure starter
You build the mission on top

F-14B(U) Pilot + Jester: IZLID Strike — you fly, Jester designates on your call (🕒 pre-release module)
Curated scripted scenario

F-14B(U) RIO + Iceman: GCI Intercept — Iceman flies YOUR calls from the back seat (🕒 pre-release module)
Curated scripted scenario

F-14 RIO: Fleet Defense — the AWG-9 vs a Backfire raid (solo or MP crew, works today)
Curated scripted scenario

Crew difficulty (for WSO/RIO templates): Qualified — clean cockpit, your calls

Step 5: template packs — era-gated like everything else, with crew difficulty.



Syria · Modern (2000s+) · blue · FA_18C_hornet from CARRIER · seed 1

[COPY SHARE LINK](#) [GENERATE .MIZ](#)

The generate bar: share link and download.

Crew Ops — fly the back seat

The backseat contract: the mission flies the jet; you run the mission. Crew Ops templates are player-paced through the **F10 CREW menu** — no scripts on a stopwatch. Commands appear as they become relevant, the AI crew answers your calls, and real events drive the feedback (“GOOD EFFECT ON TARGET” when your convoy dies).

- **F-14B(U) Pilot + Jester: IZLID Strike** — you fly the Tomcat; Jester (the AI RIO) puts the IZLID on the target when you call it from the crew menu. (Pre-release module.)
- **F-14B(U) RIO + Iceman: GCI Intercept** — you're the RIO; Iceman (the AI pilot) flies YOUR calls — commit, hold, recommit CAP — while you run the AWG-9. (Pre-release.)
- **RIO: Fleet Defense (F-14, solo or multiplayer)** — four Backfires inbound on the force; sort the raid in TWS and time the Phoenix shots. **Solo** (1 slot): you air-start level on CAP — trim, jump to the back seat, and Iceman holds the jet on your A-menu commands. **Multiplayer** (2 slots): human pilot up front, human RIO in back.

Crew difficulty: *Trainee shows [CREW HINT] prompts for the next call; Qualified gives you a clean cockpit. **Why F-14 only?** Jester and Iceman are the Tomcat's crew AI. The F-4E needs none — the Phantom's back seat has full flight controls, so a WSO player simply flies from the pit.*

Nav reference points

On maps with curated landmark data (Nevada today), named references — Area 51, Belted Peak, Student Gap, Coyote Summit and more — are marked on the **F10 map**, listed in the briefing with coordinates, plotted on the kneeboard theater page, and provided as named trigger zones (NAV BELTED PEAK) you can build your own logic on.

The standard comm ladder

Every starter uses the same predefined comms, so you learn the plan once. The ladder is printed on the in-jet kneeboard and in the mission briefing.

AGENCY	CALLSIGN	FREQ (UHF)	TACAN	NOTES
Guard	—	243.00	—	monitored
Your flight	(varies)	305.00	—	flight common
Tactical	—	254.00	—	inter-flight coordination
AWACS	Overlord	251.00	—	land-based E-3 / A-50
Tanker	Texaco	253.00	39Y	speeds & altitudes per type
Carrier	Mother	264.00	71X	ICLS 11 · Link4 336 · ACLS on
CAP	(squadron)	258.00	—	carrier air wing
AEW Hawkeye	(squadron)	259.00	—	carrier air wing
FARPs	(name)	127.50+	—	0.25 steps per pad

All carrier approach systems come pre-activated — TACAN 71X “STN”, ICLS channel 11, Link4 on 336, and ACLS. Tune and go.

Building blocks

BLOCK	WHAT YOU GET
Airfield dressing	Era- and faction-correct static aircraft on real parking stands, ground support equipment, fuel farms, tents, com
Air defenses	Complete, functional SAM sites with doctrinal layouts — SA-2/3/6/11, Hawk, Patriot by era and side — plus SH
Tanker / AWACS	On station behind friendly lines on the standard freqs. Not available in WWII — the era gate is strict.
Carrier strike group	A real CSG with a doctrine-spotted deck. See the next section.
Ambient air traffic	AI transports starting up and flying between friendly fields.
Functional FARPs	Pads with the fuel, ammo, command, and comms vehicles required for rearm and refuel to actually work.
Strike targets	Depot, convoy, and C2 packages in the enemy rear — each with a trigger zone ready for your own mission log
Practice range	Bombing ring and strafe line in the friendly rear.
Nav kneeboard	Comms card, airfield data, and a theater overview rendered into the jet's kneeboard.
Nav reference points	Named landmarks (Area 51, Belted Peak...) marked on the F10 map, in the briefing, and on the kneeboard, wi

The carrier strike group

Pick a hull and you get its **real strike group**. The Roosevelt sails as CSG-9 with USS Lake Erie (CG-70) and DESRON 23 destroyers; the Truman as CSG-8 with USS Gettysburg; the Forrestal as a 1980s Mediterranean battle group with USS Ticonderoga; HMS Invincible as the 1982 South Atlantic task force with her Leander frigates (and, true to history, no AEW); USS Essex as Task Force 58 with Corsairs for the 1944 Marianas. Screen stations follow doctrine: plane-guard destroyer astern, AAW cruiser on the beam, pickets on the bow quarters. The group steams into wind on BRC. On landlocked maps (Nevada) the carrier option greys out — there is no carrier water.

When the deck is set for flight ops (launch or recovery), the air wing's SAR helo is already airborne — **Angel**, an SH-60 holding in **Starboard Delta**: 300 ft and below, a quarter mile off the starboard beam, tracking the ship's course. Starboard, because the whole Case I pattern lives in left-hand turns on the port side; doctrine is "first off, last on" — the helo launches before the first cat shot. Each wing flies its real HS squadron (HS-6 Indians on the Roosevelt, HS-15 Red Lions on the Forrestal), up Angel common on 262.0. The 1944 Essex keeps her plane-guard destroyer astern instead — no helos in Task Force 58.

Deck configuration

DECK STATE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Recovery	Landing area clear (angle, waist cats, EL4, port stern). The bow is the pack: tight uniform herringbone rows across t
Launch	Cats, JBDs, and taxi flow clear; spares spotted aft in uniform rows.
Packed	Port-visit deck. Everything fouled including the angle. No-fly.

Check the aircraft types you want on deck — rows are spotted one squadron per row, with tugs, MJ-1 loaders, and crash gear at their real stations. Optionally launch the air wing's **CAP** (two-ship on the threat axis at 25,000

ft — e.g. VFA-146 Blue Diamonds) and an **E-2 Hawkeye** AEW orbit covering the force.

Templates are the one exception to the no-waypoints rule — the AI pilot needs steerpoints to fly. See the Crew Ops section for the WSO/RIO scenarios.

Share links and recipes

A starter is defined by its **recipe** — your wizard selections plus a seed. Share links encode the recipe, not the file: the same link always regenerates the same mission, even after DCS updates. Change the seed to reroll the details while keeping your selections.

FAQ

The mission won't load or units are missing. Make sure you own the map. Carrier decks with CVN-71/72/73/75 need the Supercarrier module; the Stennis deck works in the base game, and the Forrestal comes with the F-14.

Can I edit the starter? Yes — that's the point. Open it in the Mission Editor; everything is ordinary groups and statics you can move, delete, or build on.

Why can't I pick aircraft X in era Y? Hard era gate by service window — the Hornet entered service in 1987, so it can't appear in a Cold War (1965–1985) starter. This keeps every starter period-authentic.